A TOOL FROM NORMAN YAP, FOR PHOTOGRAPHERS WITH A DAY JOB

Can I leave my job, and when?

For wedding photographers who are already booking paid weddings. If you are not earning from weddings yet, follow along and come back when you are.

The calculator gave you a number. Prices are how you reach it, and part-timers price from what they see other people charge, not from what the business has to clear. Every tier below starts at its floor: the price that holds your 50% margin at 35 weddings a year, after overhead, direct costs, card fees and the cost of winning the booking. The floor is the minimum, not the price. Price to your market above it, and keep the ramp rising.

Weddings a year to price for

Defaults to the bookings your quit number needs at today's average. Overhead per wedding is $240 at this volume.

35 a year

TIERS — Three | **Four**

Tier name	Coverage hours	Second shooter hours	Other inclusion cash cost
The Ceremony	7	0	0

Album included: No

Your price, inc GST (0 = use the floor): 0

Share of bookings, %: 30

Floor **$2,153** Price **$2,200** Net margin **51.0%** clears Per hour **$314**

Tier name	Coverage hours	Second shooter hours	Other inclusion cash cost
The Story	10	6	0

Album included: No

Your price, inc GST (0 = use the floor): 0

Share of bookings, %: 45

Floor **$3,115** Price **$3,150** Net margin **50.5%** clears Per hour **$315** Step **x1.43**

Tier name	Coverage hours	Second shooter hours	Other inclusion cash cost
The Feature	12	10	0

Album included	Your price, inc GST (0 = use the floor)	Share of bookings, %
No	0	20

Floor **$3,756** Price **$3,800** Net margin **50.6%** clears Per hour **$317** Step **x1.21**

Tier name	Coverage hours	Second shooter hours	Other inclusion cash cost
The Heirloom	12	10	0

Album included	Your price, inc GST (0 = use the floor)	Share of bookings, %
Yes	0	5

Floor **$6,274** Price **$6,300** Net margin **50.2%** clears Per hour **$525** Step **x1.66**

The ramp rises at every step. Each tier earns at least as much per hour as the one below it, so nothing cannibalises the tier above.

Do not sell base hours plus add-on hours on every tier. That rebuilds the hourly trap. Take hour counts off anything a couple sees, put a finish time and a continuation rate in the contract, and set that rate at or above your top tier's price per hour ($525 here).

BACKWARDS FROM THE NUMBER

$3,153	$50,766	$100,800	$4,915
Average sale at this mix (30/45/20/5)	Profit at 35 weddings, before your tax	Your quit number	Average sale that reaches the number at 35 weddings

This ladder does not reach your number. At 35 weddings and this mix it is $50,034 a year short. Lift prices toward an average of $4,915, move the mix up the ladder, or add bookings. Lifting the average is the lever that does not cost Saturdays.

The floor prices only protect the margin. Reaching the quit number is a separate test, and it is the one that decides the resignation date. The share of bookings is your guess until you have twenty consults on these prices.

ADD-ONS, EACH WITH ITS OWN MARGIN

ADD-ON	CASH COST	RETAIL INC GST	MARGIN
Second photographer, 8 hours	560	1750	62.8% ok
Engagement session	0	1600	98.0% ok
Fine art album	1100	2600	51.5% ok
Extra hour of coverage	0	850	98.0% ok

Cash cost only. Your own hours on an engagement session are not a cost, they are capacity, so its margin reads high and its real price is a Saturday morning. Never discount or gift the thin ones.

WHAT PART-TIMERS LEAVE OUT

Overhead a year	$8,412
Overhead per wedding at 35	$240
Gear sinking fund a year	$0
Your wage, as the quit number	$100,800
Your own super	$10,800
GST on every sale	one eleventh
Card fees	1.78% of the sale
Marketing a year	$0
Cost per booking	$0

Every one of these sits inside the floor prices above. Income tax then comes out of what is left, which is why the quit number is a before-tax figure.

CAPACITY CHECK

About 13.0 of your hours per wedding (shooting plus culling at 0.35 an hour, editing outsourced) times 35 weddings over 45 working weeks is **10.1 hours a week** on weddings alone, before enquiries, consults and admin.

Print this page for the Module 1 worksheet. Rates as at 8 November 2026. Not tax advice.